Chapter 1 · Story

Maya arrives late. The room has already decided why.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Leo is assigning the opening shift. What is his most informative next move?

A Ask Maya about today and check her availability.

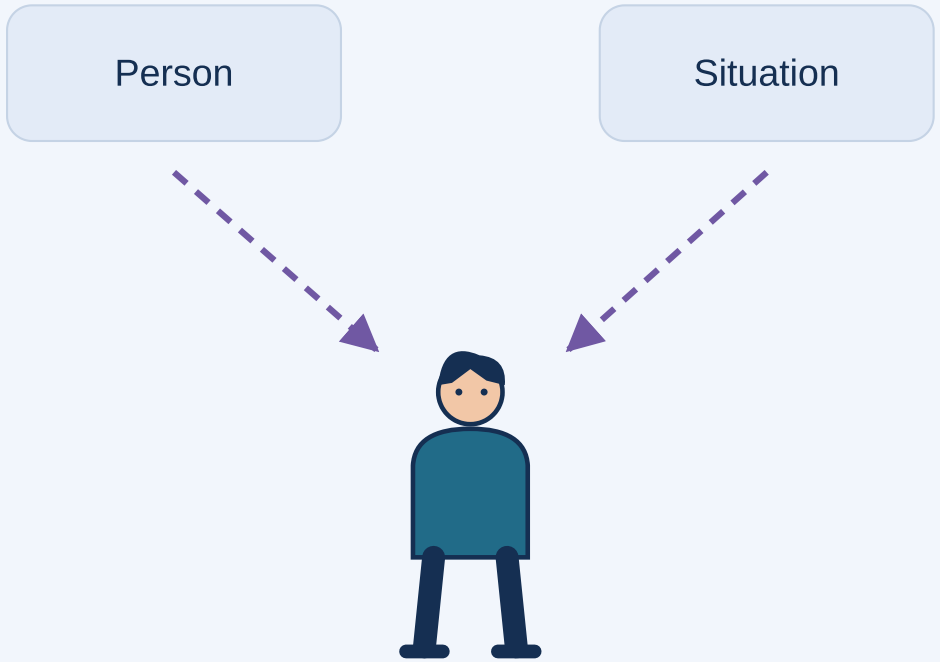
B Use today’s lateness as the main sign of reliability.

C Ignore today and assume she will arrive on time.

Suggested answer: A. Asking Maya about the delay lets Leo investigate the obstacle and plan the shift without ignoring the lateness.

Personal qualities meet circumstances.

- **Person**: tendencies, goals, beliefs, skills
- **Disposition**: a usual tendency over time
- **Situation**: demands, people, available choices
- **Interaction**: changing circumstances can change a response



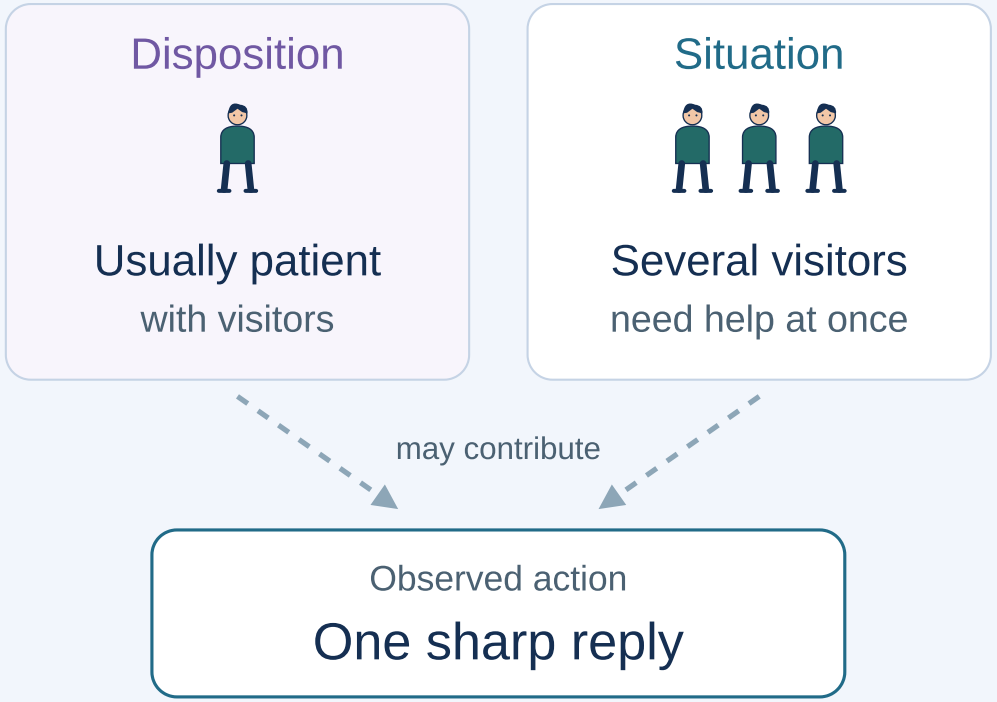
Behavior emerges in context.

A disposition is one personal quality; circumstances also contribute.

The same person, under pressure.

- **Disposition**: the volunteer is normally patient.
- **New demands**: several visitors ask for help at once.
- **Observed action**: the volunteer gives one sharp reply.
- **Check**: compare calmer and busier shifts.

A tendency meets a busy room



Compare calmer and busier shifts.

A hypothetical interaction of a disposition and a situation. Dashed paths indicate possible contributions.

Observation is not explanation.

- **Observation**: Maya arrived after the start.
- **Attribution**: Leo proposes that she does not care.
- **Different questions**: what happened, and what caused it?
- **Next step**: ask for information that could test the cause.

Two different questions

Observation



Maya arrived after the start.

A recorded action

Attribution



“She doesn’t care.”

A proposed cause

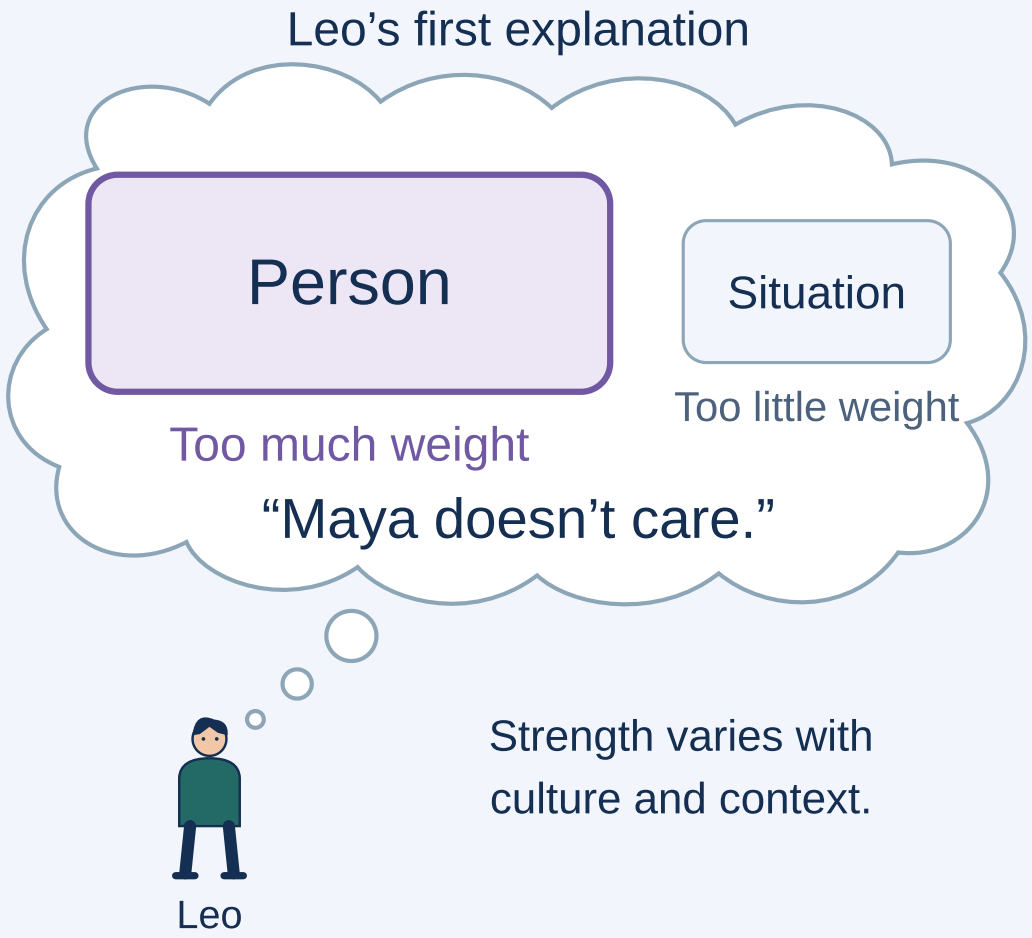
One statement records an action.
The other proposes a cause.

What evidence could test Leo’s cause?

Leo’s observation and his attribution answer different questions.

When the person gets too much weight.

- **Fundamental attribution error**: too much weight on personal qualities, too little on circumstances.
- **Leo’s first account**: “Maya doesn’t care.”
- **Missing context**: the broken lift and helping a neighbor.
- **Check**: compare plausible causes before judging commitment.

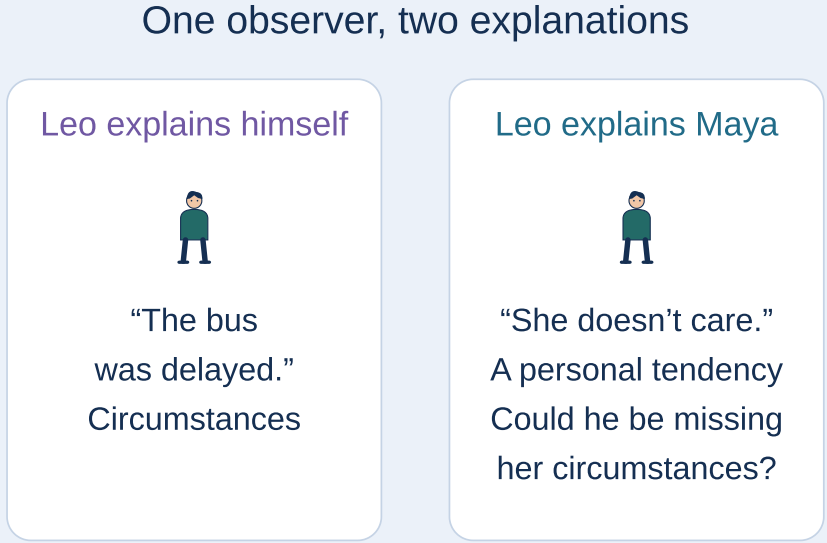


Strength varies with culture and context.

Leo gives personal qualities more weight than the circumstances.

One observer, two explanations.

An attribution is an explanation of what caused an action. Attribution research describes patterns across judgments. Those patterns do not settle the cause of one person’s action. Actor–observer differences compare how one observer explains their own actions and other people’s actions. In a hypothetical comparison, Leo might cite a bus delay for his own lateness but Maya’s priorities for hers. The pattern varies with the judgment and study design.



A possible actor–observer difference.
The pattern depends on judgment and setting.

Hypothetical explanations by the same observer.

Test the explanation.

- **Describe**: Maya arrived late; “doesn’t care” is a proposed cause.
- **Compare**: look across shifts, settings, and exceptions.
- **Check**: ask Maya and test plausible alternatives.
- **Revise**: change your confidence when the evidence changes.

Follow the evidence

Leo’s proposed cause

“She doesn’t care.”

1. **Describe the action**
   Maya arrived after the start.
   Keep the cause open.
2. **Compare occasions**
   Is lateness usual across shifts?
   Look for exceptions.
3. **Check alternatives**
   Could a travel barrier explain it?
   Ask Maya about the delay.
4. **Revise your confidence**
   Weigh the evidence for each cause.
   Allow your explanation to change.

Let evidence change your confidence.

Describe, compare, check, and revise. Apply the same steps to your own interpretations.

Try the idea somewhere new.

A volunteer misses shifts only when the bus service is suspended. What should you test?

A Whether personality alone predicts attendance.

B Whether another travel plan improves attendance.

C Whether the missed shifts can be deleted.

Suggested answer: B. Trying another travel plan tests the suspected barrier while keeping the attendance expectation clear.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> In Maya’s arrival story, what did Leo observe, and what cause did he infer?

> What evidence would strengthen an explanation based on a person’s usual tendencies, rather than one unusual situation?

1. Leo observed that Maya arrived after the meeting had started. He inferred that she did not care about the project. Her late arrival is the observation; not caring is his proposed cause.

2. An explanation based on a personal tendency becomes more credible when the behavior recurs across varied circumstances and plausible alternatives have been examined.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Choose a mildly frustrating action by another person. Write what you observed, your initial explanation, two plausible alternatives, and one respectful question that could clarify what happened.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 2 · Story

A brighter poster. More visitors. A cause?

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The poster that “worked” · c02s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Which statement fits Leo’s evidence?

A The poster caused the increase.

B The poster had no effect.

C Attendance rose; several causes remain possible.

Suggested answer: C. Saying that attendance rose preserves the observation. Leaving the cause open reflects the limits of the comparison.

Together does not establish because.

- **Correlation**: two things vary together.
- **Observed**: attendance rose after Leo changed the poster.
- **Causal claim**: the poster produced the rise.
- **Check**: what else could explain the change?

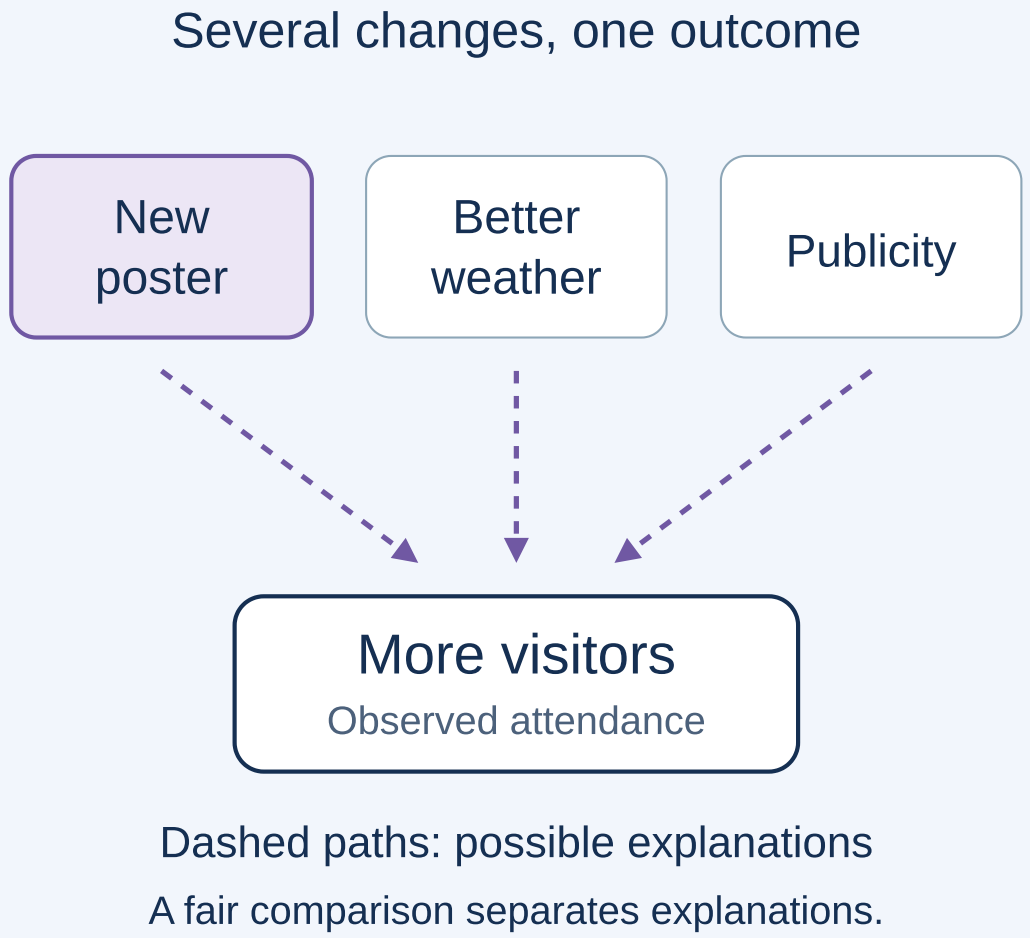
Together does not establish because

Observed pattern	Possible explanations
	
Poster changed. Attendance rose. Two things varied together.	Poster? Weather? Publicity? What would separate these explanations?

Correlation describes a relationship.
A causal claim needs a fairer test.

Several changes, one result.

- **Confound**: another factor could explain the pattern.
- **Poster, weather, publicity**: all changed together.
- **One outcome**: more people attended.
- **Problem**: this comparison cannot isolate the poster’s contribution.



Several changes can fit the same before-and-after pattern.

Select people. Assign conditions.

- **Random sampling**: select people from a population by chance.
- **Random assignment**: allocate conditions by chance.
- **Same event**: compare invitation versions A and B.
- **Limit**: assignment does not make a sample representative.

A possible selection-and-allocation design

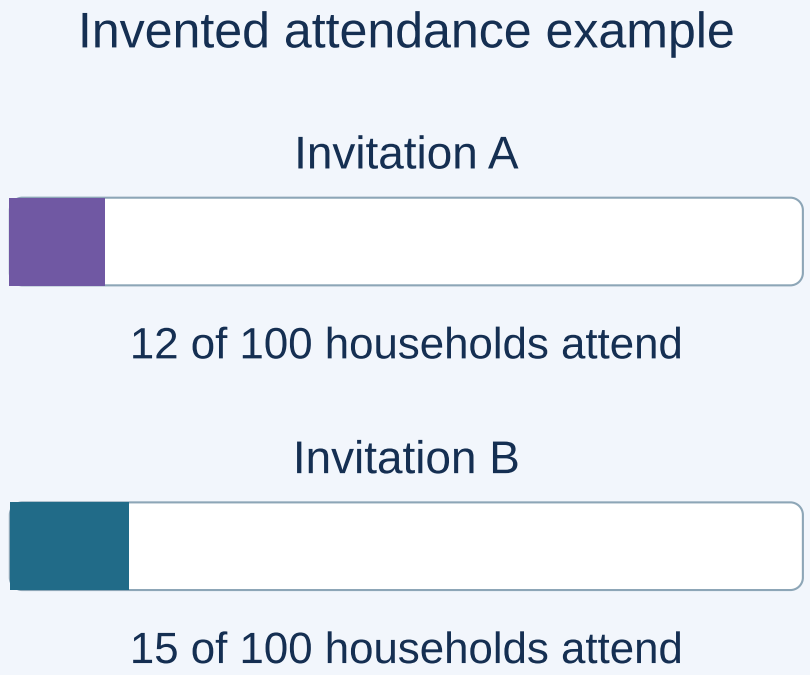
1. **Population**
   Residents we want to learn about
2. **Random sampling**
   Select people by chance
3. **Sample enters the comparison**
   Who was actually included?
4. **Random assignment**
   Allocate invitation A or B by chance

Assignment does not make a sample representative.

Choosing the sample and assigning conditions answer different questions.

How large is the difference?

- **Invented example**: 12 of 100 attend versus 15 of 100.
- **Difference**: three percentage points.
- **Uncertainty**: another sample may give a different estimate.
- **Decision**: consider the size, precision, and cost.



Invented counts illustrate the size of a difference.

Significance and usefulness are different questions.

- **Statistical significance**: evidence assessed against a specified model.
- **Practical importance**: is the difference useful for this decision?
- A significant result may be too small to matter.
- A nonsignificant result does not prove zero effect.

Two questions about a result

Statistical significance



How unusual under a specified model? Often a model of no group difference.

Practical importance



How large is the difference? Is it useful enough for the decision?

Significance does not measure usefulness.
Nonsignificance does not prove zero effect.

Model-based evidence and practical value are different questions.

What can we really conclude?

Replication repeats a test to examine how dependable a finding is. Independent tests help us learn whether a result holds up elsewhere. Preregistration records the planned methods and analysis before results are known. That advance record reduces some opportunities for selective reporting. Preregistration cannot rescue a poor design. With a sound design, a larger sample can narrow the uncertainty around an estimate. More observations cannot fix a systematically unfair comparison. Sharing the study's methods and materials lets others inspect how it was done. A memorable study is a starting point for evaluation, rather than a final verdict.

Build confidence through checks

1. **Preregister**
   Record the plan before results
2. **Run a sound comparison**
   Sample size can improve precision
3. **Share methods and materials**
   Make the work inspectable
4. **Replicate independently**
   Check how dependable the finding is

A larger sample cannot fix a biased comparison.

Plan, inspect, and independently repeat a sound comparison.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Which invitation comparison is strongest?

A Design A in winter; design B in summer.

B Randomize designs for one event; define attendance in advance.

C Design A for existing fans; design B for newcomers.

Suggested answer: B. Randomizing invitations for one event improves the comparison. Also check whether households share invitations.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> How does random assignment differ from random sampling?

> Why does the rise in attendance after Leo changed the poster fail to establish that the poster caused the increase?

1. Random assignment allocates people to conditions. Random sampling selects people from a population.

2. Other conditions can change over time and produce the same before-and-after pattern.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Find an everyday causal claim. Name its outcome, one competing explanation, and a feasible comparison. State whose behavior the result would represent.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 3 · Story

One broken toaster becomes “they always break.”

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The story that comes to mind · c03s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What most improves the estimate of repeat failures?

A A detailed account of the worst failure.

B Failures divided by comparable completed repairs.

C A vote on whose impression feels realistic.

Suggested answer: B. The total of comparable repairs provides the denominator for a failure rate. Consistent follow-up still matters.

Memorable is not the same as common.

- **Availability heuristic**: easy-to-recall examples shape judgment.
- **Base rate**: how common is it among comparable cases?
- **Denominator**: total comparable repairs, including successes.

A failure rate needs the whole record

“That toaster failed again!”

Invented record: all comparable repairs



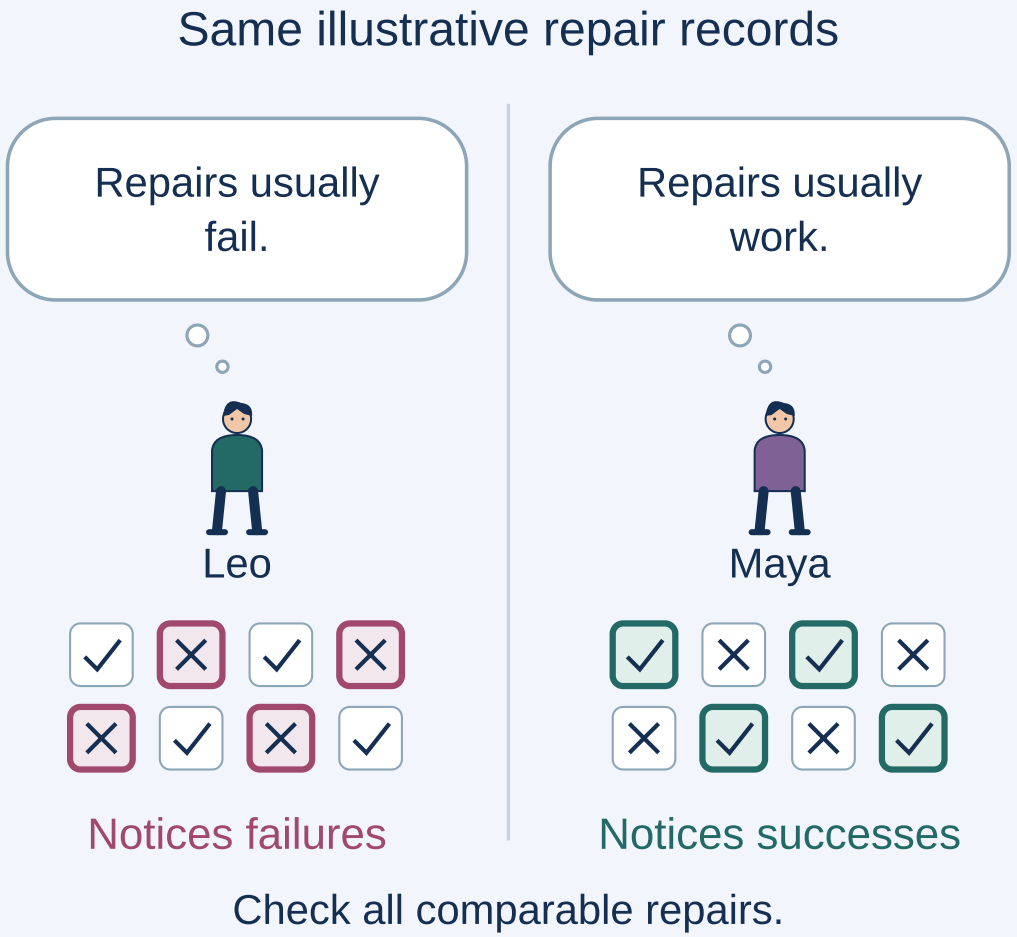
4 failures / 40 repairs = 10%

Availability is a shortcut, not a frequency count.

The invented whole record gives a vivid case its denominator.

Give a belief a fair test.

- **Confirmation bias**: seeking or interpreting evidence to fit a belief.
- Leo expects evening sessions to fail.
- Count comparable successes as well as failures.
- **Ask**: what outcome could change Leo’s view?



Expectations can change which evidence gets attention.

When a desired answer feels persuasive.

- **Motivated reasoning**: what we want to be true can shape evaluation.
- Maya wants the café's repairs to succeed.
- Use one definition of failure for every case.
- Invite a review that could challenge the preferred answer.

A desired conclusion can shape reasoning

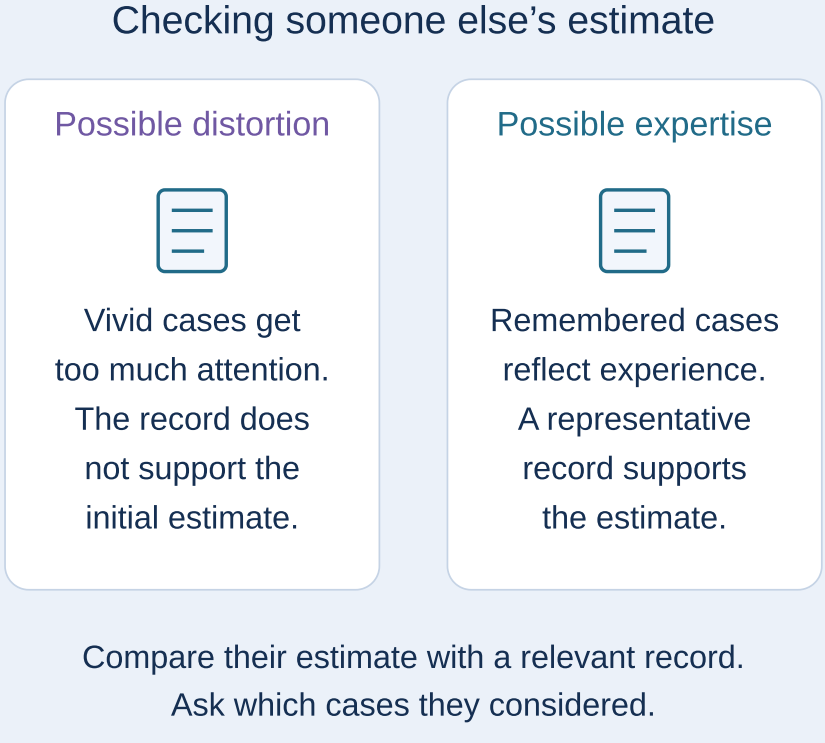
1. **Maya wants the café to succeed**
   "I hope our repairs are working."
2. **Reassuring stories feel persuasive**
   Returns get less attention
3. **Maya can use one test for all cases**
   Define failure and follow up consistently
4. **Maya can invite a challenging review**
   What could change her first belief?

A wanted conclusion can still be correct.

Maya's desired outcome may shape how she judges the evidence.

What can we really conclude?

When assessing someone else’s estimate, compare that estimate with a relevant record before proposing that it is biased. A bias label alone cannot establish how the person reached the estimate. For example, Leo’s vivid repair stories might give a distorted impression of failure. In another case, an experienced repairer’s remembered cases might accurately reflect a dependable record. Representative evidence helps distinguish these possibilities. When reviewing another person’s reasoning, ask which information they used and which cases they missed. Disagreeing with their estimate does not replace that investigation. Experts also need feedback and opportunities to revise their judgments.



Compare another person’s estimate with the record behind it.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Leo thinks evening sessions fail. Which question best challenges his belief?

A Which evenings went badly?

B Who agrees that evenings are a poor idea?

C What outcomes would make us conclude evenings work?

Suggested answer: C. Naming outcomes that would count as success gives Leo’s belief a chance to be wrong.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Why can’t Leo estimate the repair failure rate from one vivid toaster failure? What total must he count?

> When can an availability shortcut be useful?

1. The denominator is the total of comparable cases. Four failed repairs mean something different among forty repairs than among four hundred. Consistent follow-up is needed to estimate the failure rate.

2. An availability shortcut can help when the examples that come to mind reliably represent the relevant events.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Keep a small record of one everyday prediction for a week. Include successes and failures. Avoid collecting private information about others. Compare the whole record with your first impression.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 4 · Story

“I chose it” quietly becomes “it must be right.”

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What makes honest revision easier?

A Review failures and compare options afresh.

B Remind Maya that a competent coordinator would know better.

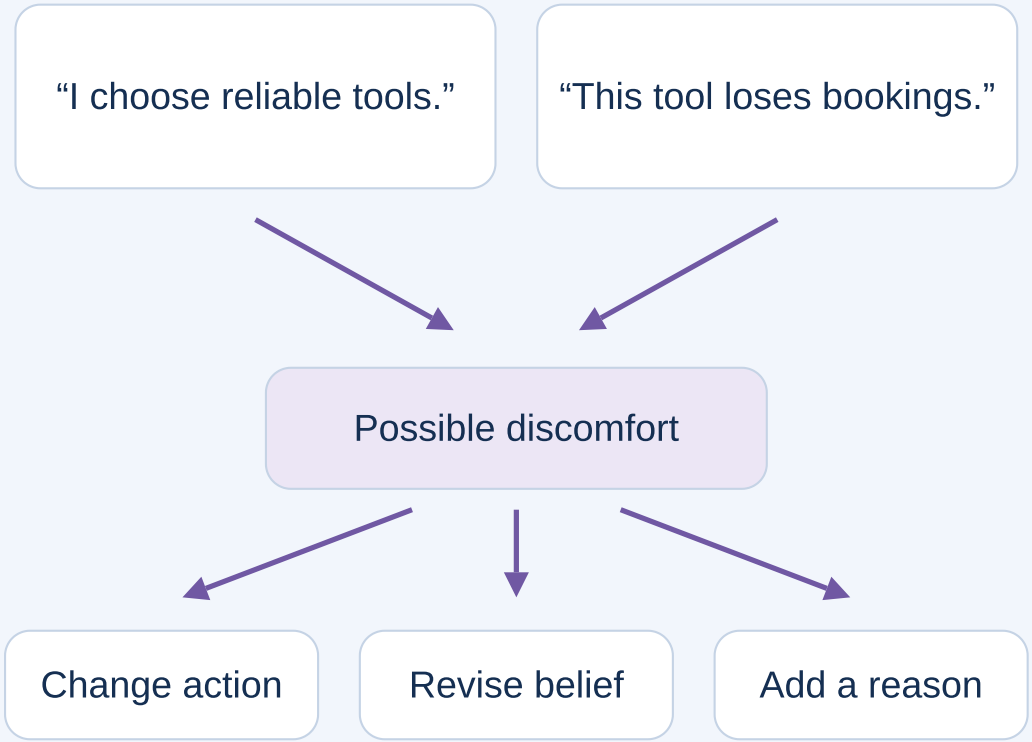
C Keep the system until the investment feels worthwhile.

Suggested answer: A. Reviewing failures and comparing options turns attention toward outcomes and the next decision.

Inconsistency can feel uncomfortable.

- **Cognitive dissonance**: inconsistency between beliefs or actions can feel uncomfortable.
- **Cognitions**: beliefs and knowledge about our actions.
- “I choose reliable tools” clashes with a system that loses bookings.
- Reduce discomfort by revising a belief or action, or adding a justification.

When beliefs and actions clash

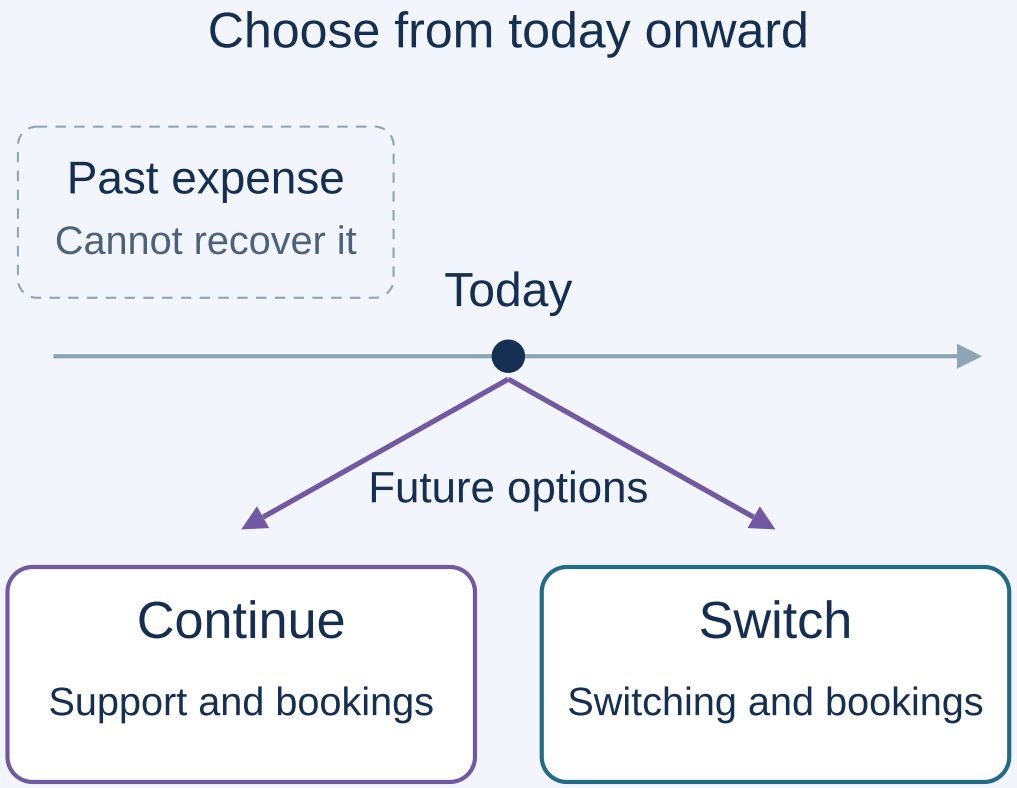


Cognitions are beliefs and knowledge about actions.

Inconsistency can motivate several different responses.

Give the future a fresh vote.

- **Sunk cost**: money, time, or effort that cannot be recovered.
- **Sunk cost effect**: letting that past expense drive the next choice.
- Compare future benefits and costs, including switching and usable skills.

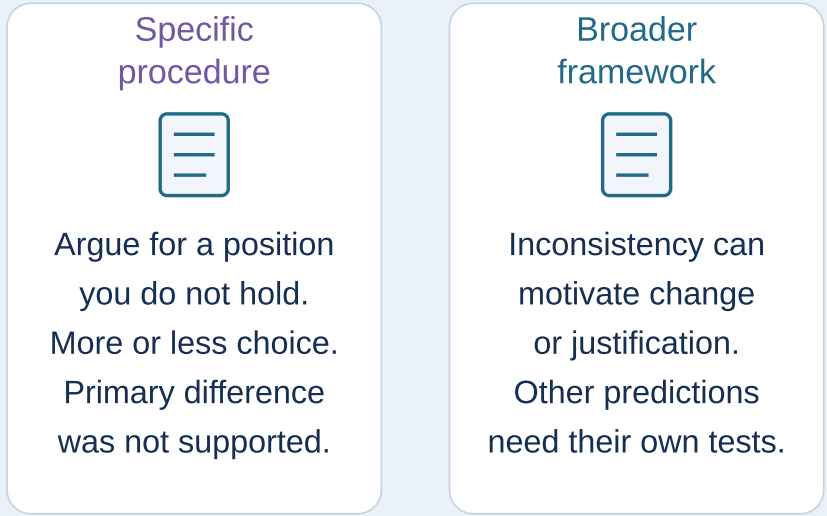


Past spending is unrecoverable; compare future consequences.

What can we really conclude?

Evidence for specific cognitive dissonance demonstrations is uneven. In 2024, researchers repeated one procedure across multiple laboratories. Participants were asked to argue for a position they did not hold, with more or less choice about doing so. This is called an induced-compliance procedure. The study tested whether the amount of choice affected later attitudes. Its primary analysis did not support the predicted difference between the higher-choice and lower-choice groups. That result challenges the particular procedure tested. It does not settle every version of cognitive dissonance theory. Distinguish the broad explanation of discomfort and justification from the evidence for a particular prediction. The linked Vaidis and colleagues study provides the details.

A tested prediction and a broader theory



The 2024 replication tests a particular procedure. Its result does not settle every dissonance claim.

The cited replication concerns a particular induced-compliance procedure.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Switching costs £100; keeping the tool costs £300 in future support. Benefits are equal. What matters?

A The large fee already paid.

B The lower avoidable future cost of switching.

C Only the emotional discomfort of switching.

Suggested answer: B. Under the stated assumptions, switching costs one hundred pounds and keeping the tool costs three hundred. Real choices also compare risks.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Name two ways to reduce dissonance.

> When can a past investment still matter?

1. People may reduce dissonance by changing a behavior or belief, or by adding a justification. Context affects the response.

2. A past investment matters when it changes future consequences, such as switching costs or usable skills.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Revisit a small commitment you can change. List the future benefits and avoidable costs of continuing or stopping. Write a sentence that permits correction without attacking your character.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 5 · Story

Everyone says yes. Has everyone agreed?

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The quiet vote · c05s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What could reveal concerns before discussion?

A Have the chair announce the preferred answer.

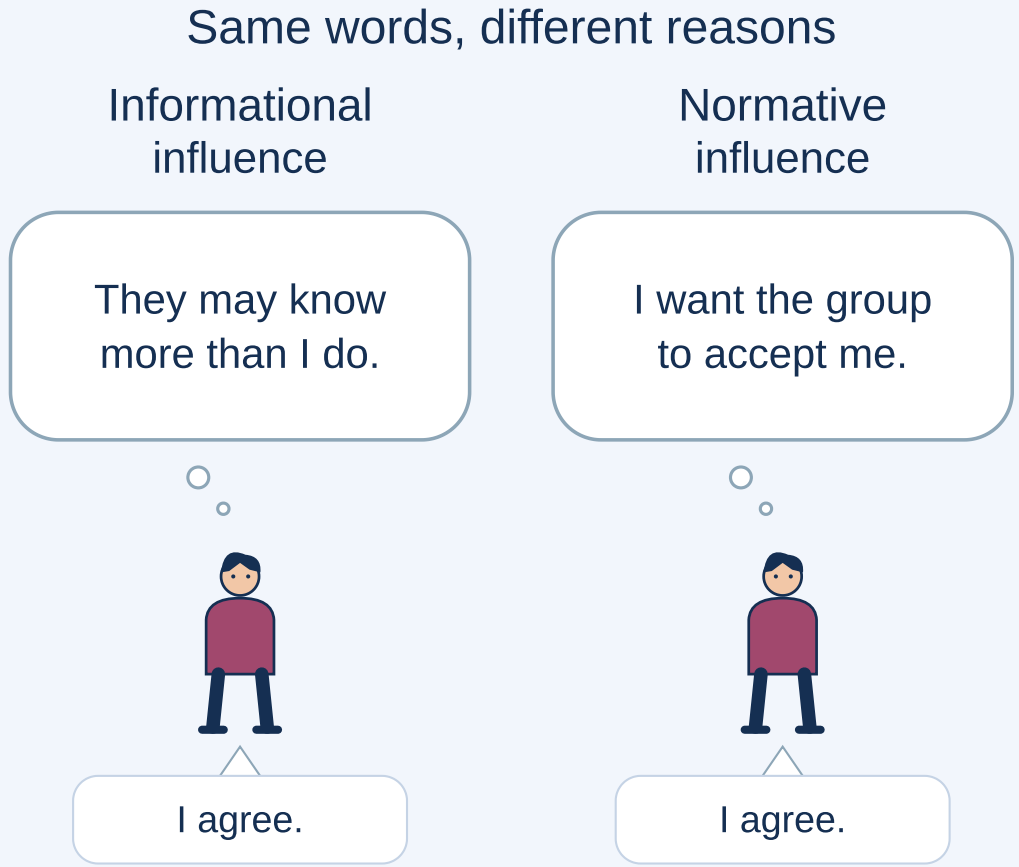
B Collect independent written judgments first.

C Ask only experienced members to speak.

Suggested answer: B. Independent written judgments let people record a view before seeing which answer has public support.

Two reasons to follow a group.

- **Informational influence**: they may know better.
- **Normative influence**: I want acceptance.
- Public agreement can differ from private belief.



The same public agreement can reflect different private reasons.

A request and an authority’s order.

- **Compliance**: responding to a request.
- **Obedience**: responding to an authority’s order.
- An authority’s request can involve both.
- The role can add pressure; resistance remains possible.

A request and an authority’s order

Compliance



Leo asks Sam: “Cover my shift?” Sam agrees to the request.

Obedience



The chair instructs: “Skip the check.” The authority role can add pressure.

An authority’s request can involve both. People can question or resist.

Authority can add pressure; it does not make resistance impossible.

Make questioning possible before work continues.

- **Notice**: a required equipment check is being bypassed.
- **Pause**: use the café’s agreed stop rule.
- **Raise**: use the agreed route for the concern.
- **Review**: clarify responsibilities before proceeding.

Make questioning practically possible

1. **A required check is bypassed**
   Notice the concern
2. **Pause the unsafe work**
   Use an agreed stop rule
3. **Raise the concern**
   Use the agreed escalation route
4. **Review before proceeding**
   Relevant training and responsibilities

An instruction does not remove accountability.

An agreed route makes a concern actionable.

What can we really conclude?

In Asch’s line-judgment studies, participants compared line lengths after hearing a group give incorrect answers. The studies examined when people would follow a majority despite the visible evidence. In Milgram’s studies, an experimenter urged participants to continue a task they believed delivered electric shocks to another person. The studies examined responses to apparent authority in a highly structured setting. Both sets of studies raise questions about methods, ethics, and how widely their findings apply. Their results concern particular conditions of influence; they are not universal obedience rates. Some participants resisted, and responses varied with the conditions. Harmful conduct is not inevitable.

Different tasks, specific pressures

Asch’s task



Compare line lengths after a majority gives incorrect answers. Some people resist.

Milgram’s task



An experimenter urges continuation. Participants believe another person receives shocks.

Methods, ethics, and conditions matter.
These are not universal obedience rates.

Task, setting, ethics, and variation limit generalization.

Try the idea somewhere new.

The chair requests bypassing a required check. Which process helps?

A Let the first confident person decide.

B Allow anonymous complaints afterward.

C Pause and use an agreed safety escalation route.

Suggested answer: C. An agreed stop-and-escalation route makes questioning possible while the safety decision still matters.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Distinguish normative and informational influence.

> Why can public agreement overstate private agreement?

1. Normative influence concerns acceptance. Informational influence treats other people’s responses as evidence.

2. Public agreement can hide private doubt when people copy early answers, suppress concerns, or assume that others have checked.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

For an agreed, low-stakes group choice, have everyone write a view before discussion. Compare the range of initial reasons with what a show of hands might have revealed.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 6 · Story

Two invitations. Different reasons to care.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The invitation · c06s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

A potential volunteer worries about the time commitment. What information would help most?

A A second celebrity endorsement.

B Shift length, support, and an optional trial.

C A stronger claim that this is unmissable.

Suggested answer: B. Shift length, support, and an optional trial give the volunteer relevant information about the commitment.

An evaluation is not a sign-up.

- **Attitude**: an evaluation of something.
- A resident may see volunteering as worthwhile.
- Time, transport, support, and choice also affect action.
- Decide which outcome the invitation should support.

An attitude is an evaluation

Possible evaluation



“Volunteering is worthwhile.” Reasons and values shape the judgment.

A different question



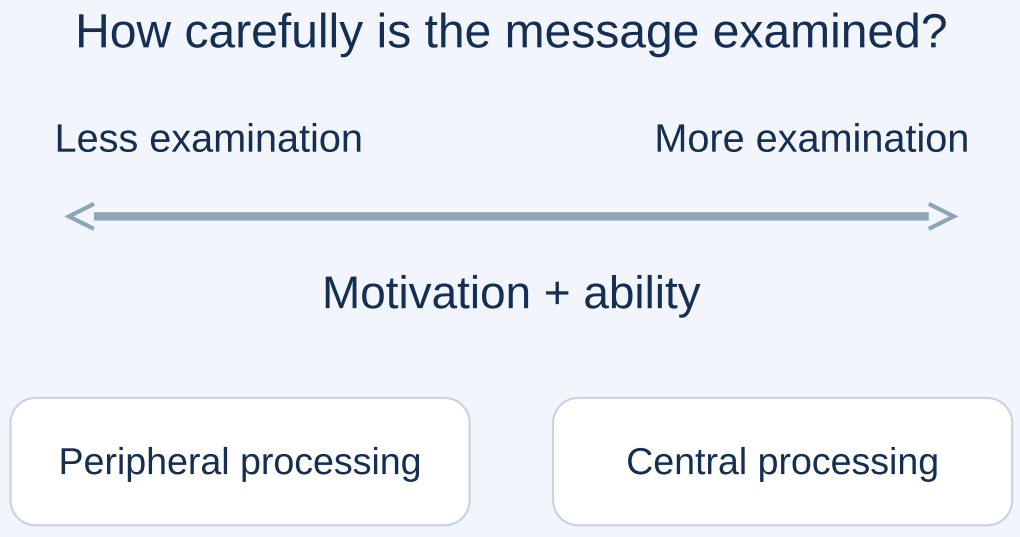
Will I sign up? Time, transport, support, and choice also affect action.

A positive attitude does not guarantee action.
Ask what outcome the message needs to support.

An evaluation and an action are related but distinct.

How carefully is the message examined?

- **Elaboration likelihood model**: motivation and ability shape examination.
- **Central processing**: examine relevant arguments.
- **Peripheral processing**: give more weight to cues such as familiarity.
- These are processing differences, not fixed kinds of person.



The elaboration likelihood model describes processing, not fixed types of person.

The same person can process different messages more or less carefully.

Check the truth of a norm claim.

- **Descriptive norm**: what people do.
- **Injunctive norm**: what people approve.
- Both example claims need evidence.
- Highlighting common nonparticipation can normalize it.

What happens and what is approved

Descriptive norm



“Many residents volunteer.”
A claim about what people do.

Injunctive norm



“Our community values volunteering.”
A claim about what people approve.

These are example claims; check their truth.
Highlighting low participation can normalize it.

Behavior and approval are different claims; both need evidence.

Help someone make an informed choice.

- **Reason**: what would this contribution achieve?
- **Commitment**: state time, effort, and support.
- **Next step**: make questions or a supported trial possible.
- **Choice**: leave room to decline.

Help someone make an informed choice

1. **A relevant reason**
   What would this contribution achieve?
2. **A concrete commitment**
   Time, effort, and available support
3. **An easy next step**
   Ask questions or try a supported shift
4. **Room to decline**
   Measure understanding and informed choice

Remove unsupported claims about what others do.

Support understanding and preserve meaningful choice.

What can we really conclude?

Persuasion depends on the audience, topic, source, and outcome being measured. A changed survey answer is not the same outcome as sustained behavior change. For the café team, the next task is to evaluate its revised invitation. More clicks show increased attention; they do not establish that potential volunteers understood the commitment or will keep volunteering. The team can track comprehension, informed sign-ups, and continued participation. To learn about the volunteers' experience, ask them whether they understood the effort involved and felt able to decline. Their answers provide information that the organizers' impressions alone cannot supply.

Measure the outcome that matters

1. **Attention**
   An invitation gets a click
2. **Understanding**
   The person knows the commitment
3. **Informed sign-up**
   Participation is freely chosen
4. **Continued participation**
   Check experience and retention

A click alone does not establish these later outcomes.

Measure later outcomes rather than assuming them from clicks.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Few residents currently volunteer. Which invitation is defensible?

A “Everyone here already volunteers.”

B “Hardly anyone helps—don’t be like them.”

C “Try a supported two-hour shift; here is what it involves.”

Suggested answer: C. A supported two-hour trial is a concrete, checkable request. Its effect on informed participation still needs evaluation.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> What makes central processing more likely?

> Distinguish descriptive and injunctive norms.

1. Central processing is more likely when someone is motivated and has the ability, attention, and information to examine the arguments.

2. Descriptive norms concern what people do. Injunctive norms concern approval.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Rewrite a low-stakes invitation. State the decision, relevant reason, effort required, and next step. Remove social-proof claims you cannot substantiate.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 7 · Story

Two teams stop sharing a table.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



When “we” takes over · c07s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

The shared checklist is unfinished. What is a useful first change?

A Agree on owners, deadlines, and needed support.

B Tell everyone their commitment is disappointing.

C Copy more people onto every task.

Suggested answer: A. Agreed owners, deadlines, and support make responsibility clearer and help people coordinate the work.

Who counts as our team?

- **Social identity**: groups help define who we are.
- An in-group is a group someone sees as us.
- **In-group favoritism**: favoring members of that group.
- Group preference can produce unequal treatment without explicit hatred.

Who counts as “our team”?

Repair volunteers



“Give our team first choice of shifts.” Group membership can shape preference.

Welcome volunteers



Their contribution can be overlooked. Favoritism can create unequal access without explicit hatred.

Check workload, incentives, and decision power. A shared name alone does not change those.

Make the shared goal workable.

- **Shared outcome**: a successful visitor experience.
- **Handover**: agree information, tools, and timing.
- **Participation**: share decisions, credit, and burdens.
- **Check**: a shared name alone does not change incentives or power.

One visitor experience needs both teams

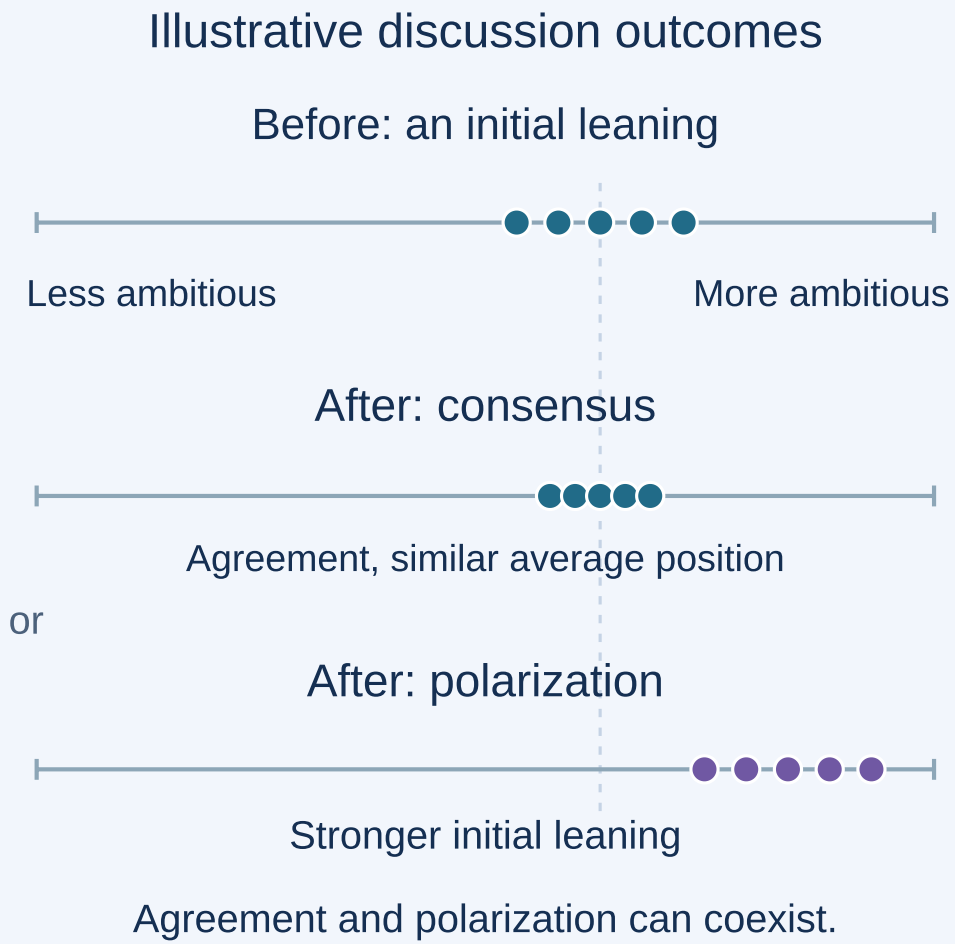
1. **Welcome the visitor**
   Understand the need
2. **Plan the repair**
   Agree roles and resources
3. **Coordinate the handover**
   Tools, timing, and information
4. **Review the visitor experience**
   Share credit, burdens, and decisions

A shared goal needs workable arrangements.

Shared identity needs coordination, resources, and decision rights.

Discussion can strengthen an initial leaning.

- **Group polarization**: discussion can intensify an initial leaning.
- The team may move from a small event to a week-long festival.
- Consensus means agreement; polarization concerns direction and extremity.
- Compare independent views before and after discussion.



Agreement can form with or without a more extreme leaning.

Poor output can have different causes.

- **Social loafing**: individual effort can fall in pooled work.
- **Coordination loss**: genuine effort is poorly combined.
- The unfinished checklist alone establishes neither process.
- Check effort, tools, sequencing, and roles.

Similar poor output, different processes

Social loafing



Individual effort
falls in pooled work.
“My contribution
will go unnoticed.”
A possible process.

Coordination loss



Effort can be high.
Work is duplicated.
A needed tool
arrives too late.
Tasks do not align.

An unfinished task alone does not identify either.
Check effort, tools, sequencing, and roles.

Different processes require different remedies.

What can we really conclude?

Groupthink describes cases where pressure for agreement interferes with critical discussion. A poor decision alone does not establish that this process occurred. To review the café’s planning meeting, look at what happened during the discussion. Which concerns were withheld? Which information was repeated or missed? Were roles or incentives unclear? Then choose a change that addresses the process you found. Independent estimates can broaden the evidence. Clear roles can improve coordination. Structured disagreement can make concerns easier to express. These changes help the team investigate the decision without pretending to know every member’s private thoughts.

Agreement can hide unspoken doubts

1. **Pressure for agreement**
   Relevant concerns remain unspoken
2. **Examine the actual process**
   Whose information was missed?
3. **Collect independent views**
   Make contrary evidence discussable
4. **Review the decision**
   Clear roles and structured disagreement

A poor decision alone does not establish groupthink.

Ask members about their concerns and check which information reached the discussion.

Try the idea somewhere new.

An event budget keeps escalating without checking demand. What helps?

A Ask members to show stronger enthusiasm.

B Gather independent estimates and contrary evidence.

C Open with the chair’s preferred budget.

Suggested answer: B. Independent estimates and contrary evidence give the group information beyond its existing enthusiasm.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> How does polarization differ from consensus?

> How can a willing group still perform poorly?

1. Consensus is agreement. Polarization is movement toward a more extreme position from an initial leaning.

2. A willing group can still lose output through poor sequencing, duplicated work, missing tools, or unclear roles.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Choose a shared project you know well. Map each task, its owner, what must happen before it can start, and when progress will be checked. Identify one plausible obstacle and a check that could distinguish it from another explanation before proposing a remedy.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 8 · Story

“Anyone can join.” The form says otherwise.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The invisible doorway · c08s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

How should the team investigate unequal access?

A Ask whether organizers consider themselves fair.

B Trace who can enter each stage and where people drop out.

C Add a fairness slogan to the poster.

Suggested answer: B. Tracing each stage can reveal access barriers that intentions and slogans miss.

Separate belief, attitude, and action.

- **Stereotype**: a generalized group belief.
- **Prejudice**: an attitude toward a group, often involving dislike.
- **Discrimination**: unequal treatment based on group membership.
- Evidence about one does not establish everything about the others.

Three related, distinct concepts

Stereotype: a group belief

“Every newcomer lacks repair skills.”

Prejudice: an attitude

“I dislike newcomers before meeting them.”

Discrimination: unequal treatment

Reject someone for being a newcomer.

These need not form an inevitable sequence.

Belief, attitude, and action are related but distinct.

Follow the route into participation.

- **Recruitment**: who never hears about the opportunity?
- **Requirements**: who lacks the tools or resources to enter?
- **Timing**: who cannot attend during working hours?
- **Evidence**: examine access and outcomes, not intentions alone.

A welcoming intention can leave barriers

1. **Recruit through existing friends**
   Who never hears about the opportunity?
2. **Require personally owned tools**
   Who lacks the resources to enter?
3. **Meet during working hours**
   Who cannot attend?
4. **Inspect the process and outcomes**
   Intentions alone cannot establish fairness

Rules can favor an existing group.

An arrangement can exclude without an openly hostile statement.

Contact needs meaningful participation.

- **Intergroup contact**: interaction between members of different groups.
- Support cooperation, shared goals, equal status, and organizer backing.
- Sharing a room is not the same as sharing decisions.
- Check whether newcomers can actually participate.

Sharing a room and sharing participation

Limited participation



Newcomers watch. Established members control the tools and decisions.

Cooperative contact



Work on a shared goal. Share relevant tools and decision-making. Organizers support equal participation.

Intergroup contact can help under some conditions. Check actual access and participation.

Cooperation, equal status, shared goals, and support matter.

Change the rule that creates the barrier.

- **Procedural change**: remove an unnecessary entry requirement.
- **Example**: open applications beyond existing friends.
- **Example**: share specialist tools where feasible.
- Evaluate access, progression, and participation; protect privacy.

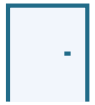
Change the barrier in the process

Existing rule



Apply through existing friends.
Bring your own specialist tools.

A proposed change



Open the application.
Use relevant criteria.
Provide shared tools where feasible.
Track participation.

A friendly encounter alone leaves the rule intact.
Use follow-up and protect privacy.

Examine who can enter and participate after the change.

What can we really conclude?

An explicit attitude is an evaluation someone reports directly. An implicit association is a link between ideas that may be measured indirectly, such as through the speed of responses in a sorting task. Discriminatory behavior concerns how people are actually treated. When interpreting a participant's implicit-association score, remember that it is not a complete diagnosis of that person's character or a forecast of every action. When evaluating a recruitment change, inspect access and participation: who can apply, progress, and remain involved? Include follow-up and the experiences of applicants. An organizer saying "I am fair" cannot establish that those outcomes are fair. Interpret small samples cautiously and protect privacy. Investigating unequal access does not justify collecting unnecessary personal information.

Different measures answer different questions

Explicit attitude

What someone reports directly

Implicit association

An indirect response pattern in a task

Behavior and access

Who can apply, progress, and participate?

No single score is a complete character diagnosis.

Different measurements do not supply a complete character diagnosis.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Friend referrals become an open skills-based application. How can improvement be assessed?

A Check whether organizers feel more inclusive.

B Compare the friendliness of form wording.

C Track applications, progression, and participation using relevant criteria.

Suggested answer: C. Applications, progression, and participation can show where barriers remain. Interpret those outcomes with context and privacy safeguards.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Give an example of discrimination without an openly hostile statement.

> Why might a contact event leave unequal access unchanged?

1. An irrelevant requirement or restricted network can exclude a group without an openly hostile statement.

2. Contact can leave unequal access unchanged when decision power, incentives, status differences, or procedures remain the same.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Review a process you are authorized to examine. Identify an unnecessary barrier, propose a change, and select a fair outcome measure without collecting unnecessary personal data.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 9 · Story

Friendship begins with the quiet shift.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

A newcomer hopes to make friends. What is a respectful starting point?

A Offer a shared activity and notice reciprocal interest.

B Share increasingly private details until closeness develops.

C Keep arranging contact after invitations are declined.

Suggested answer: A. Offering a shared activity creates an opportunity to connect. Notice whether the other person also chooses to participate and shows interest.

Shared settings create opportunities.

- **Proximity**: closeness creates opportunities to meet.
- **Similarity**: shared interests can support conversation.
- Sam and Leo share a shift and an interest in old radios.
- Connection still depends on mutual willingness.

A shared shift creates opportunities

1. **Sam and Leo meet on Thursdays**
   Proximity changes who becomes familiar
2. **They discover an interest in radios**
   Similarity can support conversation
3. **They choose further conversation**
   Look for reciprocal interest
4. **Either person can set a boundary**
   Contact creates no right to friendship

Connection is possible, not guaranteed.

Shared settings create opportunities, with mutual willingness.

Familiarity has conditions and limits.

- **Mere exposure effect**: repeated encounters can increase liking in some conditions.
- An unfamiliar face may become more comfortable to see.
- Repetition can also intensify annoyance or threat.
- A stated boundary still matters.

Repeated encounters can have different effects

Possible familiarity



A face becomes more comfortable to see.
Liking may increase.

A different response



Unwanted contact can intensify annoyance or threat.
More is not automatically better.

The mere exposure effect depends on conditions.
A stated boundary still matters.

Familiarity has limits and does not override boundaries.

Closeness depends on the response.

- **Disclosure**: sharing something personal.
- **Responsiveness**: helping someone feel understood and cared for.
- **Reciprocity**: mutual consideration over time.
- Check what support is wanted before offering advice.

Closeness depends on the response

1. **Leo discloses something personal**
   “It has been a difficult week.”
2. **Sam listens and checks understanding**
   “Have I understood what you mean?”
3. **Sam asks what support Leo wants**
   Listening, practical help, or advice?
4. **Reciprocity over time**
   Mutual consideration, not matching secrets

Disclosure needs willingness and responsiveness.

Connection depends on what each person wants and how the other responds.

Respond to the preference someone states.

- Attachment describes patterns studied in close relationships.
- Labels are not diagnoses.
- Sam’s refusal states a preference for now.
- Leo can accept it and leave future contact optional.

A declined invitation is useful information

What Sam says



“I need time alone.”
An expressed preference for now.

Leo’s response



Accept the refusal.
Leave future contact optional.
One occasion does not establish an attachment style.

Attachment labels describe studied patterns.
They are not diagnoses or permission to persist.

Leo can respect Sam’s preference without inferring an attachment style.

What can we really conclude?

Much relationship research examines associations or asks people to report their own experiences. Self-reports provide information about those experiences, but people may remember events differently or answer in ways they prefer others to see. Samples may also represent only particular cultures or relationship forms. Suppose similar partners report greater satisfaction. That association does not, by itself, establish that making two people more similar would improve their relationship. Other factors might contribute to both similarity and satisfaction. To apply that research to Sam and Leo, first ask about their actual experiences and preferences. Their conversations may reveal relevant details that a group average cannot settle. A research pattern cannot decide what either person should want.

An association and an individual relationship

Study reports



Some partners report greater similarity and satisfaction. Self-reports can have limitations.

Sam and Leo’s situation



Ask Sam and Leo about their experiences and preferences. A group average cannot choose their goals.

Association alone does not establish an intervention. Ask about the pair’s actual experience.

Use research to frame questions, then ask about Sam and Leo’s own experiences and preferences.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Sam declines an invitation and needs time alone. What should Leo do?

A Diagnose an avoidant attachment style.

B Accept the boundary and leave future contact optional.

C Increase contact to use the familiarity effect.

Suggested answer: B. Accepting the invitation refusal respects Sam’s stated preference without inventing a diagnosis.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> How can proximity affect friendship?

> Why is disclosure alone insufficient?

1. Proximity changes opportunities to interact and discover shared interests.

2. Disclosure alone is insufficient because willingness, responsiveness, trust, context, and mutual boundaries also matter.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

During a willing everyday conversation, ask an open question. Summarize what you heard and invite the person to correct your summary before offering advice. Afterwards, reflect on your own responses and the feedback the person actually gave.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

Chapter 10 · Story

A crash. A full room. A moment of hesitation.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



Who will do something? · c10s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Why could concerned bystanders hesitate?

A Concern disappears when groups become large.

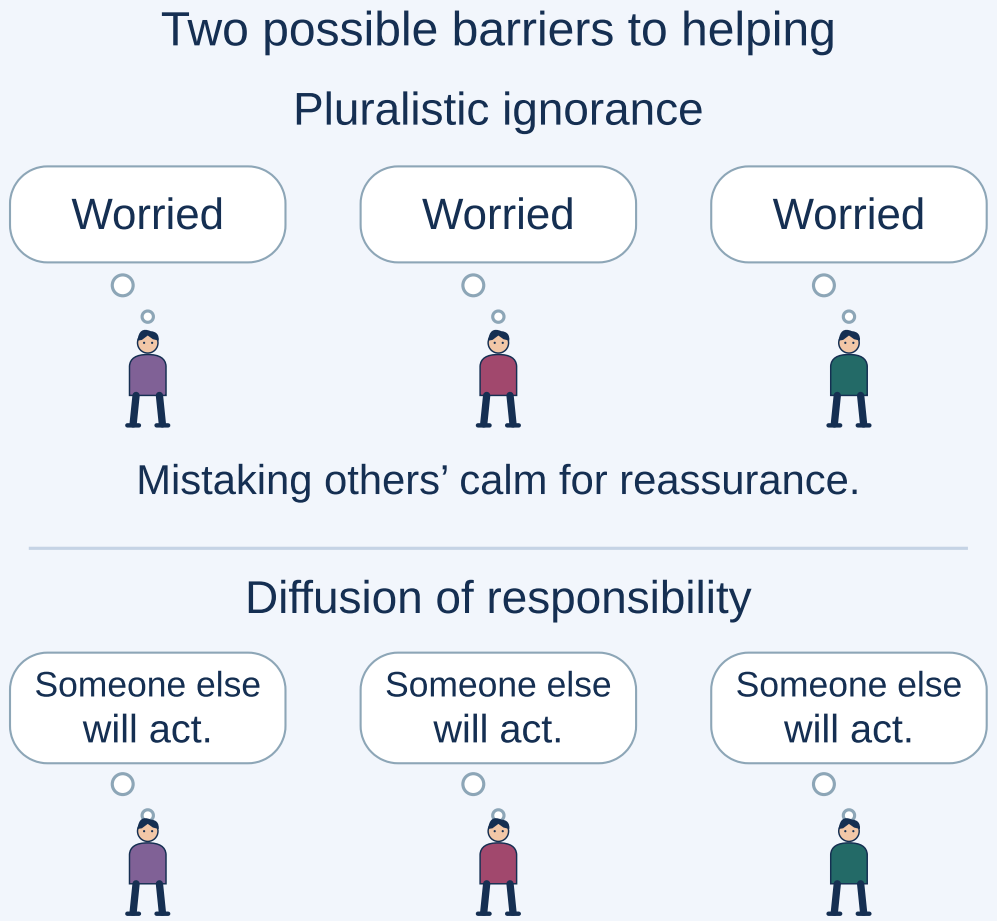
B People may be uncertain and assume someone else will act.

C Hesitation proves nobody cares.

Suggested answer: B. People may be unsure whether help is needed, or think someone else is responsible for acting.

Two reasons concerned people may hesitate.

- **Bystander effect**: others' presence can reduce an individual's likelihood of helping.
- **Diffusion of responsibility**: someone else will act.
- **Pluralistic ignorance**: others look calm, so perhaps no help is needed.
- Context can also make other people a source of help.



In some settings, others' presence can reduce an individual's likelihood of helping. These are two possible processes; context, skills, and support also matter.

Give concern a workable next step.

- **Notice**: clarify what needs attention.
- **Responsibility**: agree who will take the next step.
- **Action**: use appropriate skills, training, and support.
- **Review**: check the outcome for a low-risk shared task.

Turn concern into a safe path to action

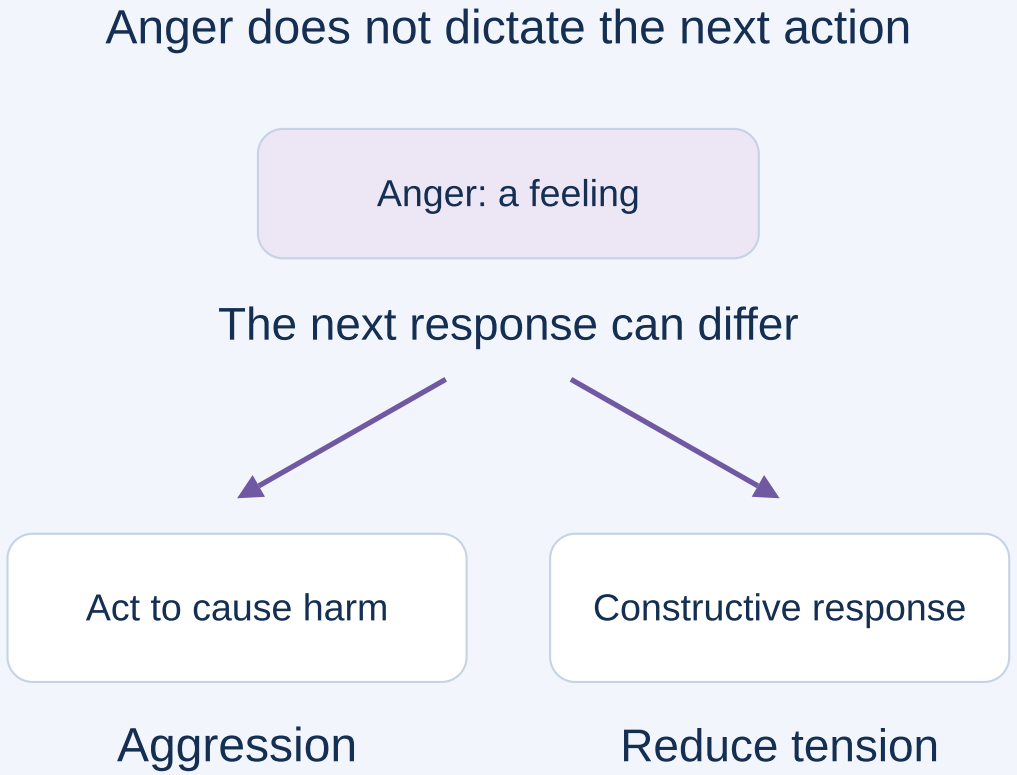
1. **Notice and interpret the need**
   Clarify what is happening
2. **Accept responsibility**
   Agree who will take the next step
3. **Identify an appropriate safe action**
   Use available skills, training, and support
4. **Act and review**
   For a low-risk task, check the outcome

In emergencies, follow local guidance and training.

Clear responsibility, skills, and support can make action feasible.

Anger leaves a choice about action.

- **Aggression**: behavior intended to harm.
- Anger is a feeling; it does not determine the next action.
- **De-escalation**: reduce tension and the risk of harm.
- Context helps explain conduct without removing responsibility.



De-escalation aims to reduce the risk of harm.
Context helps explain behavior; accountability remains.

A feeling does not predetermine a harmful action.

Turn a shared aim into coordinated work.

- **Cooperation**: coordinate contributions toward a shared outcome.
- Name roles and provide resources and support.
- Agree how problems will be raised.
- Review contributions, benefits, burdens, and feedback.

Make a shared task workable

1. **A clear shared outcome**
   What needs to be done?
2. **Named roles and resources**
   Who owns each step and has support?
3. **A route for reporting problems**
   What happens if the plan becomes unsafe?
4. **Feedback and a fair division**
   Review contributions, benefits, and burdens

For example, name who checks the replacement shelf.

A specific arrangement can turn a shared aim into coordinated work.

What can we really conclude?

Laboratory studies may measure aggression through controlled tasks, such as choosing an unpleasant noise for another participant. Such measures are imperfect indicators of serious violence outside the laboratory. Bystander findings also vary with danger, relationships, and available support. “Crowds don’t help” hides those differences and cannot explain every incident. For a real emergency, follow local guidance and your training. A social psychology explanation does not replace first-aid instruction. Evaluate practical changes by whether appropriate, safe help becomes more available. A team saying it cares does not establish that its response plan works.

A research measure and a real-world decision

Controlled measure



An unpleasant-noise task measures one laboratory response. It is an imperfect proxy for serious violence.

Real-world context



Danger, relationships, training, and support can change what safe help is possible. Crowds can also help.

Interpret the measure within its limits.
A psychology model does not replace training.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Which preparation makes future help more likely?

A Tell everyone to be more caring.

B Assume the most senior person handles all incidents.

C Agree on response roles, training, and a call-for-help route.

Suggested answer: C. Roles, training, and a call-for-help route address ability and responsibility as well as good intentions.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Distinguish diffusion of responsibility from pluralistic ignorance.

> Imagine you are reviewing the café’s response to the fallen shelf. Choose two ideas from earlier chapters and explain how each would improve the review.

1. Diffusion of responsibility concerns who should act. Pluralistic ignorance concerns how people interpret others’ reactions.

2. For an incident review, separate observations from blame, compare possible causes, invite independent accounts, or assign clear roles. These draw on chapters one, two, five, and seven.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Design a helping plan for a low-risk shared task: signal, named role, safe action, and feedback. Explain how context, evidence, influence, and group structure shape your plan.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.